Committee: Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)

Topic: Tackling Child Labour and Exploitation in Global Supply Chains

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1. Introduction

Child labour and the exploitation of children remain significant international concerns, particularly within global supply chains, where goods are produced across multiple countries before reaching consumers. Child labour occurs in industries such as agriculture, mining, manufacturing and construction, often under hazardous conditions that threaten children's health, safety and education.

According to estimates published by the International Labour Organization and UNICEF in 2025, roughly 138 million children worldwide were engaged in child labour in 2024, including 54 million in hazardous work. These figures demonstrate the continuing scale and severity of child labour worldwide.

Identifying exploitation within global supply chains is challenging because production often involves numerous suppliers, subcontractors and intermediaries. Companies that sell products internationally also have little insight into how their products' components were produced and who produced them. Even when companies have formal anti-exploitation policies, child labour can still exist in their supply chains.

Child labour is connected to poverty, lack of education, ineffective labour inspections, informal employment, and inadequate social protection. Children may be compelled to contribute to household income due to financial hardship, while some businesses exploit child labour to reduce production costs.

Solving this problem requires international cooperation. Governments must enforce labour laws, businesses must exercise responsibility throughout their supply chains, and international organizations must support prevention, monitoring, and rehabilitation. ECOSOC provides a place for delegates to discuss practical measures that protect children while considering economic development, national sovereignty, and the needs of vulnerable families.

2. Definition of Essential Terms

a) **Child labour** - Work that deprives children under the minimum working age of their childhood, their potential, and their dignity, and that is harmful to physical and mental development. It may also include work that interferes with a child's education or exposes them to dangerous conditions.

b) **Global Supply Chain** - A global supply chain is the worldwide network of suppliers, manufacturers, warehouses, and distributors involved in producing and delivering a product to customers across multiple countries.

c) **Hazardous Work** - Hazardous work is work carried out under dangerous or unhealthy conditions that could result in a child being killed, injured or made ill because of inadequate safety and health standards. Some injuries or health problems may result in permanent disability or may not become apparent until adulthood.

d) **Forced Labour** - All work or service extracted from any person under the menace of a penalty and for which the person has not offered themselves voluntarily.

e) **International Labour Organization (ILO)** - Specialized agency of the United Nations that aims to advance social and economic justice while promoting international labour standards.

f) **Supply Chain Transparency -** The ability to identify and track the different suppliers, manufacturers, and production processes involved in making a product. Greater transparency helps companies and governments identify labour violations, including child labour, throughout global supply chains.

3. General Context

Child labour has existed for centuries and was particularly prevalent in agricultural communities and during the Industrial Revoltuion, when children were frequently employed in factories, mines and small workshops under hazardous working conditions. Although international legal frameworks have been established and access to education has expanded, child labour remains a significant global challenge.

According to data published in 2025 by the International Labour Organization and UNICEF, approximately 138 million children were engaged in child labour in 2024, including 54 million in hazardous work. Poverty remains a major contributing factor, as financial insecurity can compel families to rely on their children's income. In some regions, educational opportunities remain limited due to financial barriers or inadequate infrastructure. Armed conflict and displacement can further increase children's vulnerability to exploitation, while insufficient enforcement of labour laws allows these practices to persist.

Child labour is closely connected to global supply chains, which involve complex international networks of production, manufacturing and distribution. Children may be employed in sectors such as agriculture, mining and textile manufacturing, with products from these industries entering international markets. For example, in West Africa, child labour remains a concern in cocoa production, particularly in Côte d'Ivoire and Ghana, two of the world's largest cocoa producers. Similarly, children have been involved in cobalt mining in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, where the mineral is extracted for use in electronic devices and batteries. Because multinational corporations frequently rely on suppliers and subcontractors, identifying labour violations throughout production networks can be difficult. Although some companies have

established monitoring and supplier inspections, these measures do not always identify or prevent exploitation.

Several international legal instruments address child labour. The ILO has adopted two major conventions: Convention No. 138 establishes minimum age requirements for employment, while Convention No. 182 prohibits the worst forms of child labour, including slavery, trafficking, and hazardous work. The United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child provides additional protections, particularly through Article 32, which addresses economic exploitation. Target 8.7 of the Sustainable Development Goals called for the elimination of child labour in all its forms by 2025; however, this target was not achieved. Despite these international commitments, implementation and enforcement remain inconsistent, particularly in informal sectors where labour inspections are limited.

Addressing these challenges require stronger legal enforcement, greater corporate transparency and improved access to education and social protection. Governments, businesses and international organizations must coordinate their efforts to prevent exploitation and support affected communities. ECOSOC delegates should focus on developing practical solutions that hold companies accountable while addressing the underlying causes of child labour, including poverty and inequality. These measures should strengthen the protection of children's rights while considering the economic challenges faced by vulnerable communities.

4. Key Parties Involved and their Perspectives

a) International Labour Organization (ILO) - Works to eliminate child labour by establishing international labour standards, supporting labour inspections, and assisting governments in enforcing minimum working ages. It promotes the implementation of Conventions No. 138 and No. 182 and encourages international cooperation to protect children from exploitative working conditions.

b) United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) - UNICEF focuses on protecting children's rights by promoting access to education, healthcare and social protection. UNICEF emphasizes addressing the root causes of child labour, particularly poverty and limited educational opportunities. It also supports children removed from exploitative work by promoting their rehabilitation and reintegration into education.

c) Governments and National Authorities - Responsible for enforcing labour laws, investigating violations, and protecting children within their territories. Developing countries may emphasize the need for funding and technical assistance to strengthen enforcement and address poverty. Importing countries may focus on corporate accountability and supply chain transparency. They may introduce regulations to prevent the import of goods linked to exploitation.

d) Multinational Corporations and Businesses - Play an important role in addressing child labour because their supply chains may involve suppliers and subcontractors across different countries. Businesses can help combat child labour by monitoring suppliers, conducting human rights due diligence, and reporting transparently on working conditions. However, they may face challenges due to high monitoring costs and the complexity of international production networks.

e) Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs) - Investigate cases of exploitation, raise awareness, advocate for stronger child protection measures and support affected communities. They encourage governments and businesses to improve accountability while helping children access education and rehabilitation programmes.

f) Key Countries and Importing Markets - Ghana and Côte d'Ivoire are among the world's largest cocoa producers, where child labour remains a significant concern, particularly in agricultural communities. Both countries have introduced initiatives to reduce child labour but continue to face challenges related to poverty, limited educational access, and labour law enforcement. Meanwhile, the United States and the European Union have introduced measures

aimed at preventing products linked to forced labour from entering their markets and strengthening corporate accountability. These different approaches highlight the importance of cooperation between producing and importing countries in addressing child exploitation throughout global supply chains.

5. Questions to Consider

1. How can ECOSOC encourage governments to reduce child labour in global supply chains?
2. Should multinational corporations be required to follow international human rights standards, and how can these standards be enforced fairly in countries with different economic resources?
3. What can the international community do to address child labour caused by poverty without negatively affecting vulnerable families and small businesses?
4. What measures can be taken to improve supply chain transparency and prevent companies from concealing exploitative working conditions?
5. How can countries balance international trade regulations with the protection of children's rights?
6. What role should independent inspections, worker reporting mechanisms, and digital tracking systems play in identifying and preventing child labour?
7. How can ECOSOC support access to quality education and social protection in communities where child labour is widespread?
8. Should countries introduce trade restrictions or penalties against businesses linked to child labour?

6. Suggested Research Resources

a) International Labour Organization (ILO) - Conventions No. 138 and No. 182

Website:https://www.ilo.org/international-programme-elimination-child-labour-ipec/ilo-conventions-child-labour

These conventions establish international standards concerning minimum working ages and the elimination of the worst forms of child labour. They are useful for understanding governments' legal responsibilities and the international framework for protecting children from exploitation.

b) UNICEF

Website: https://www.unicef.org/

UNICEF provides research and statistics on child labour, including its effects on children's education, health and development. Its resources also examine how poverty, limited access to education and inadequate social protection contribute to child exploitation.

c) United Nations Sustainable Development Goals

Website: https://sdgs.un.org/goals/goal8

Sustainable Development Goal 8 promotes decent work and economic growth, while Target 8.7 specifically addresses the elimination of child labour. This resource provides information on international commitments and progress towards reducing child exploitation.

d) International Labour Organization and UNICEF — Child Labour: Global Estimates 2024, Trends and the Road Forward

Website:https://www.ilo.org/sites/default/files/2025-06/2024%20Global%20Estimates%20of%20Child%20Labour%20Report.pdf

Published in 2025, this report provides updated global estimates of child labour, including regional trends, hazardous working conditions and the underlying factors contributing to exploitation. It is particularly useful for understanding the scale of the issue and identifying areas requiring further international action.

e) United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child

Website: https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/convention-rights-child

Article 32 establishes children's right to protection from economic exploitation and hazardous work. The Convention provides an international legal framework for understanding states' obligations to prevent child labour and protect children's rights.

f) Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) - Guidelines for Multinational Enterprises on Responsible Business Conduct

Website:https://www.oecd.org/content/dam/oecd/en/publications/reports/2023/06/oecd-guidelines-for-multinational-enterprises-on-responsible-business-conduct_a0b49990/81f92357-en.pdf

These guidelines outline expectations for multinational corporations regarding responsible business practices, human rights due diligence and supply chain accountability. They are particularly relevant for examining how businesses can identify and address labour exploitation within international production networks.

7. Conclusion

Child labour and exploitation in global supply chains remain serious international challenges that undermine children's rights, sustainable development and fair international trade. Even though legal frameworks exist at both national and international levels, enforcement remains inconsistent, particularly in informal economies and complex supply chains involving multiple suppliers and subcontractors.

Addressing child labour requires more than penalties and corporate inspections. Effective solutions depend on stronger legal protections, responsible business practices, access to quality education and social protection for vulnerable families. International cooperation is essential to ensuring that these measures address both exploitation and its underlying economic causes.

ECOSOC delegates should focus on developing practical, cooperative and measurable solutions. These may include providing technical and financial assistance to developing countries, strengthening supply chain transparency, improving labour inspections and establishing accessible reporting mechanisms for labour violations. Such measures must also consider the economic circumstances of developing countries and avoid unintentionally increasing children's vulnerability to more dangerous forms of employment.

Ultimately, efforts to eliminate child labour should extend beyond removing children from exploitative working conditions. They must also ensure that children have access to education, adequate protection and opportunities for long-term development.

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